

What a mouthful!

If you tried to swallow a large piece of food without chewing it, you would probably choke. You must first grind it up by repeatedly bringing your teeth together to chop and crush it into smaller pieces. While you chew, the food is moistened with saliva, and moved and mixed up by your tongue. In addition to making food moist, saliva contains an enzyme that starts to digest it.

DOWN THE HATCH

The first part of the digestive system, the mouth, contains the teeth and tongue. Slippery saliva rushes into the mouth from three pairs of salivary glands situated under the tongue and in front of the ears. Saliva lubricates the food as it is chewed into a pulp. A ball of food is then pushed into the throat and travels down the esophagus to the stomach.

The roof of the mouth is called the hard palate.

A duct from the parotid gland carries saliva to the mouth.

The incisor teeth cut up food as it enters the mouth.

The tongue moves food between the teeth, and tastes it.

Two pairs of glands release saliva under the tongue.

The parotid gland releases saliva into the mouth.

Esophagus

Trachea

OPEN WIDE

Adults have a full set of 32 teeth, which vary in shape and size according to what they do. Chisel-like incisors cut and slice food, while pointed canines grip and pierce. Farther back are the premolars and molars, which chew and grind food between the pointed tips of their crowns.

